

PURPOSE: To give students on “O” or Premium Plans flexibility in signing out during the school day when they have no attendance responsibilities to fulfill

INTRODUCED BY: Jaelyn Lister

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE MISSISSIPPI SCHOOL OF MATHEMATICS AND SCIENCE SENATE:

SECTION ONE (REASONING):

Sign-out policies carry the intention of keeping our student body safe and well-accounted for, and they do so successfully. However, they have redundancies which carry no real benefit. This change to those policies would create a balance between student safety, responsibility, and overall development. It does not allow for students to leave campus without proper monitoring or more than enough time to return. It simply allows students who have already proven themselves through their privilege plans to explore their independence without unnecessary restriction.

The current sign-out policy states that a student is unable to leave campus before 2:00 p.m. on a school day (Monday-Thursday). Leaving at this time, however, is no different than leaving campus at any earlier time in the day. In fact, if the goal of this current policy is to ensure students learn to allocate an appropriate amount of time to their academic and extracurricular attendance responsibilities, it is failing to strive for that.

Each MSMS student has their own unique schedule which cannot be grouped within one policy such as the current one. For example, some students, especially on B and C days, are often completely free with the exception of one or two class periods lasting 1.5 hours. However, the current policy remains the same. High-achieving students, even with no responsibilities dictated by their studies or extracurriculars, must stay on campus until 2:00 p.m. or the end of their last class.

It is already apparent that how a student spends their free time is completely decided on by their personal preference. A student can go to Hogarth Dining Center, Subway, their dorm, Fant Memorial Library, or even the gym at any time during the school day, as long as they do not have class, and nearly all students do. As suggested, free time for MSMS students is spent on campus however they please, and there is no evidence supporting the inappropriate nature of students going off campus within an extended period of free time—especially if said students have achieved Premium Plan or “O” Plan.

Also, on the weekends, when generally all students have no attendance responsibilities, sign-outs begin at 8:30 a.m., and there is no defined limit to how many times a student can leave. Simply put, the school week should be approached with this same behavior, for the current policy creates an unnecessary restriction on the independence of high-achieving students.

Given the proposal to allow sign outs during the school day (Monday-Thursday), privilege plans also need revision. Since the earlier sign out times would only be available to those on “O” or

Premium Plan, and the Extended and Standard Plans must specify that they do not include such a privilege, it is reasonable for this to be listed in the box labeled: “SIGN OUT LIMIT”.

Ultimately, this proposal encourages a uniform level of flexibility over the entire week, and its implementation would promote the development of independence within the student body.

SECTION TWO (SPECIFIC CHANGE):

On pages 103-105 of the Student Handbook (PDF pages 108-110), under the section titled “SIGN IN & SIGN OUT / OFF CAMPUS PERMISSION”, the following would be changed to:

RL.82. In general, no routine sign outs are allowed before 2:00 p.m. or the end of the student’s last class if later than 2:00 p.m., Monday – Friday. However, a student on “O” or Premium Plan can also complete a sign out, within Columbus City Limits, anytime between 8:30 a.m. and 11:00 a.m. if they have a gap or 2 or more hours in their schedule. The Residence Hall Staff reserve the right to decline any unreasonable amount of time off campus. Return time will be determined by the privileges the students have earned and their mode of travel or by how soon their next class begins, as students on “O” or Premium Plan must return to campus at least 30 minutes before their class period.

RL.87. Generally, students ~~Students~~ may walk off campus during the school week between 2:00 p.m. and 6:30 p.m. (5:30 p.m. when daylight savings time ends, but always before dusk) by properly signing out. However, students on “O” or Premium Plan may also walk off campus between 8:30 a.m. and 11:00 a.m.

RL.94. Daily sign outs begin after 2:00 p.m. or after students finish their last class, whichever is later. However, students on “O” or Premium Plan can also sign out between 8:30 a.m. and 11:00 a.m. if they have a gap or 2 or more hours in their schedule.

RL.97. Daily sign outs begin after 2:00 p.m. or after students finish their last class on Friday, whichever is later. However, a student on “O” or Premium Plan can sign out between 8:30 a.m. and 11:00 a.m. if they have a gap or 2 or more hours in their schedule. If there is no sufficient gap, sign outs begin after students finish their last class on Friday. Students signing out for an overnight destination may sign-out after their last class ends. Saturday and Sunday walking sign outs may begin at 8:30 a.m.

On pages 126-127 of the Student Handbook (PDF pages 131-132), under the section titled “EARNED PRIVILEGE PLANS”, the following would be changed to:

THE "O" PLAN

(Only offered to seniors)

ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA		PRIVILEGES	
GRADES	QPA: 3.8 – 4.0 (no rounding) No NC and no C's Outstanding ONLY in Wellness, Residential Living, and Work Service	STUDY HOURS	3 days off
DISCIPLINE	No more than 1 Level I No Level II or III No Saturday School	SIGN OUT LIMIT	7 hours <u>Hall Directors reserve the right to not permit 8:30 a.m.-11 a.m. sign-outs if deemed necessary (RL.82)</u>
ATTENDANCE	No unexcused absences No more than 1 tardy during the nine-week period	CAR USE	Monday – Thursday for general errands [4 hours; local; in by 10:00] 5 general purpose sign-outs [4 hours; local; in by 10 p.m.] 3 special event sign-outs [48 hours prior permission from the Hall Director

THE "PREMIUM" PLAN

(Offered to juniors and seniors)

ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA		PRIVILEGES	
GRADES	QPA: 3.0 – 3.79 (no rounding) No NC and no C's 2 Outstanding and 1 Satisfactory in Wellness, Residential Life, and Work Service	STUDY HOURS	2 days off
DISCIPLINE	No more than 2 Level I No more than 1 Level II	SIGN OUT LIMIT	6 hours

	No Level II Exceptions or Level III No more than 2 hours Saturday School		<u>Hall Directors reserve the right to not permit 8:30 a.m.-11 a.m. sign-outs if deemed necessary (RL 82)</u>
ATTENDANCE	No unexcused absences No more than 2 tardies during the nine-week period	CAR USE	2 times Monday – Thursday for general errands [4 hours; local; in by 10:00] 4 general purpose sign-outs [4 hours; local; in by 10 p.m.] 3 special event sign-outs [48 hours prior permission from the Hall Director

THE "EXTENDED" PLAN

(Available to juniors and seniors)

ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA		PRIVILEGES	
GRADES	QPA: Below 2.5-2.9 (no rounding) No NCs Satisfactory ratings in Wellness, Residential Living, and Work Service	STUDY HOURS	1 day off
DISCIPLINE	No more than 3 Level I No more than 1 Level II No Level III No more than 4 hours Saturday School	SIGN OUT LIMIT	5 hours <u>Only after 2:00 p.m. or the end of the student's last class if later than 2:00 p.m. (Monday-Friday)</u>
ATTENDANCE	No more than 1 unexcused absence No more than 3 tardies in the nine-week period	CAR USE	1 time Monday – Thursday for general errands [3 hours; local; in by 10:00] 3 general purpose or special even sign-outs

THE "STANDARD" PLAN

(Offered to juniors and seniors)

ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA		PRIVILEGES	
GRADES	QPA: Below 2.5 (no rounding) Any Unsatisfactory in Wellness, Residential Living, and Work Service	STUDY HOURS	Required
DISCIPLINE	No more than 4 Level I No more than 2 Level II No Level III No more than 6 hours Saturday School	SIGN OUT LIMIT	4 hours (weekend) With permission <u>only after 2:00 p.m. or the end of last class if later than 2:00 p.m.</u> (weekdays) *Students on Standard Plan must obtain sign-out permission from the Residence Hall Director, Director of Student Affairs or the Director of Academic Affairs to leave campus during the week.
ATTENDANCE	No more than 2 unexcused absences No more than 4 tardies in the nine-week period	CAR USE	Only on weekends